



Disruptive consolidation?

Reflections on human-machine communication
as media audience engagement paradigm

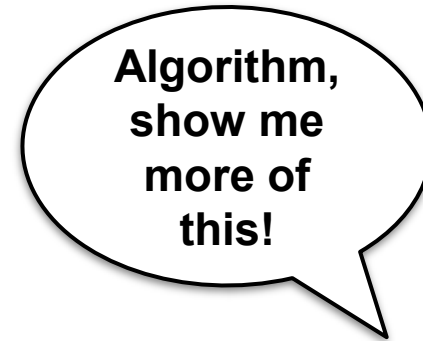
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HMC as media engagement paradigm

Attempt to locate HMC within a broader context of media audience engagement...

- ... to contextualise the human and cultural elements of HMC (Natale & Guzman 2022).
- ... to help bridge the micro and macro gap in HMC scholarship (Hepp et al. 2024).
- ... to further unpack situated and practical dynamics of human and machine configuration (Suchman 2007).

Adding on existing conceptual bridges to audience studies like domestication (Kennedy and Wilken 2023), encoding / decoding (Lomborg and Kapsch 2019), uses and gratifications research frameworks (e.g., Xu et al. 2022).



(user scenario and comment from Instagram Reels platform)

Methods and case

1.5 years **digital ethnography of TikTok** consumption.
Group of 30 young adults based in the United Kingdom.



Digital fieldwork on TikTok (6 months)



Interviews (1 year; every 3 months)

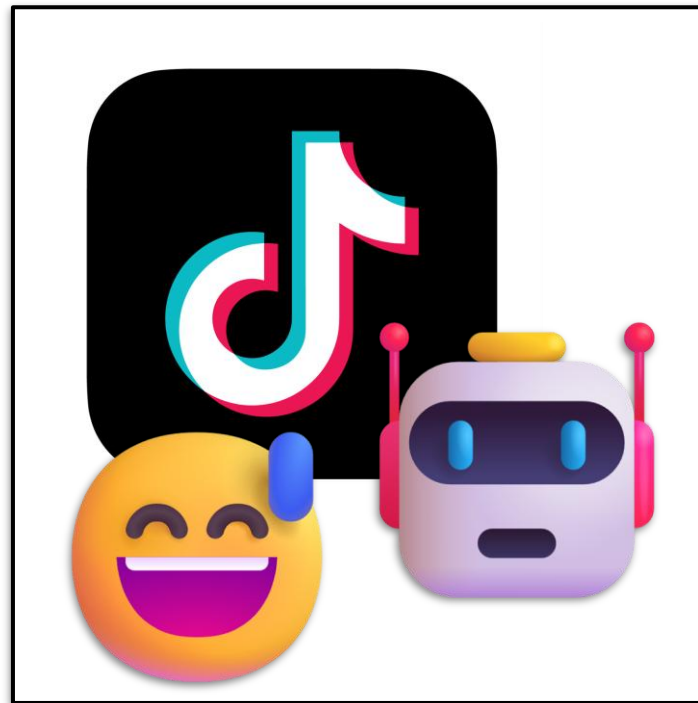


Media repertoire mappings



Participant observations

Engagement with **related scholarship** on TikTok and other algorithmic systems as “digital companions” to everyday meaning-making (Karakayali et al 2017).



Machines that speak to you

- Users perceive “**the algorithm**” as a singular entity that they interact with, gets their feelings, they (attempt to) communicate with, and receive at times messages from.
- The importance of imagination and **listening** (Bucher 2023) to an observed other, such as a machine - even when they are not explicitly speaking.
- TikTok users perceive their interactions with “the algorithm” as communicative - a **dialogue** unfolding in their interaction on the content feed (Siles et al. 2024).



“I think the algorithm ... is talking to me through TikTok”
(Participant quoted in Cotter et al. 2024)

Emotional realism of media and machines

- HMC mirrors dynamics of interpersonal communication (Hepp and Loosen 2023), foregrounding **meaning making** that happens **with the machine** as interaction partner (Guzman 2018).
- The **interpretative work** through which audiences connect with emotionally real stories (Ang 1985), too, reveals forms of meaning being produced “with” an interaction partner (e.g., Herzog 1941).
- Similarities with studies finding people feeling that **algorithms “get” and “understand”** them at a personal level (e.g., Siles et al. 2019).



If you have friends in, you have to go down to their level. They are sometimes so dumb. The radio people are more interesting. I love being with them.



I like to listen to Ma Goldberg and see how she goes about fixing things. It gives me something to think about when I am sewing. She teaches me what to do.



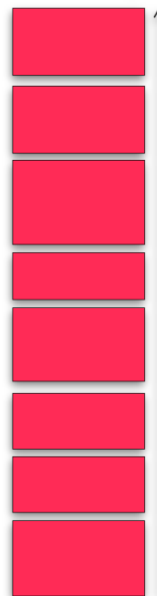
My husband died and my brother had a stroke. I really don't have anybody to talk to, and I would have needed advice in the tragedy which happened to my daughter. Dr. Brent is such a fine man. It helps me to listen to him. I really have him right in my room.

Participants quoted in Herzog 1941

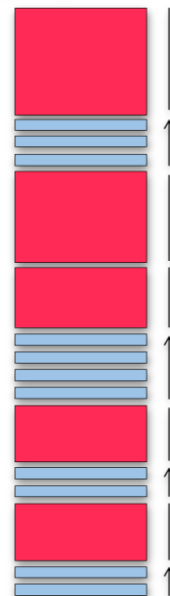
Forms of significant audience activity

- Machines “speaking back” significant change (Guzman 2018). Yet, continued importance of what Silverstone (1994) defined as **significant activity** - e.g., ways of listening (Bucher 203).
- While audience are always “active”, significant activities **semantically and materially shape the meaning** and power dynamics of the medium in question (Silverstone 1994).
- Example of “**reading for personalisation**” (Schellewald 2023). Participants enacted feelings of personalisation - of being seen and addressed by “the TikTok algorithm” - through strategically skipping unpersonalised content and searching for cues in content that resonate with self-identity.

Videos scheduled by TikTok's recommender system



Videos experienced by person reading for personalisation



Consolidation of media engagement in HMC

- Where interaction relies on the “co-production of a contingently unfolding and dynamic world” (Suchman 2021: 79), **humans** continue to carry a **significant burden** in HMC as they do in media engagement.
- Practices - and specifically those of listening to machines (Bucher 2023) - create a **historical bridge** to the position of audiences in media engagement paradigms.
- HMC consolidates complexification of **audience positionalities** (Livingstone 2018) and importance of **cultural contextualisation** in shaping how media and machines materialise (Siles 2023, Ge et al. 2024).



Disruptions to media engagement in HMC

Disruption in the particularities of media interactivity (Guzman 2018) - resultantly an added layer of complexity to audience activities as they **navigate of probabilistic machine outcomes**

- Digital irritation: how machines and their unexpected outcomes / behaviours evoke an eerie presence in their material and affective manifestation (e.g., Bucher 2017, Ruckenstein 2023, Ytre-Arne and Moe 2020).
- Strategic ignorance: the “mental gymnastics” that people have to perform to engage with the artificial as real today (e.g., Kanthawala et al. 2023, Siles et al 2019).
- Materiality of “reading”: from turning pages or surfing channels to being “in touch” with digital machines and their outputs - like reading for personalisation (e.g., Schellewald 2023).



Digital irritation



Strategic ignorance



Materiality of reading

Locating the question of power in HMC

Bridging the micro-macro gap:

Power materialises in the “**interaction order**” (Goffman 1983) of the human-machine communication process - the mutual integration of the self into societal formations through media engagement (Silverstone 1994) and literacy (Williams 1974).

Significant activity is thus one creating meaning within - and potentially through resistance against - the constraints of dominant interaction orders, **configuring** the human and machine in **meaningful ways** (Suchman 2007).



Configuration of machine process (e.g., Eisenmann et al. 2024).



Interaction and interface design limitations (e.g., Swart 2021).

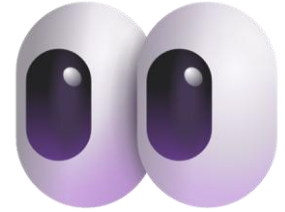


Discursive semantics of machine power (e.g., Beer 2018).



Structuration by existing social scripts (e.g. Gambino et al. 2020).

HMC and Audience Research



Continuation of audience practices where meaning, and power negotiated, through acts of reading, listening, watching ... attuning the self with machine (Bucher 2023, Siles 2023).

That is, a continuation in the literacy and audience engagement with media...

- put into context and converted into meaning (e.g., in the “moral economy” of the home; Silverstone 1994)
- where artificial and imagined turn into real matters (e.g., through reading for “emotional realism”; Ang 1985).

“...there was no way to teach [someone] to read the Bible which did not also enable [them] to read the radical press...”

Williams (1974: 135)

Thanks!

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